

DEVELOPER'S FIELD GUIDE • PRE-OFFER ASSESSMENT

The 10-Point "No-Go" Checklist

What I check before making an offer — built from \$23M+ of completed Adelaide coastal projects. Ordered by deal-killer severity. Run through this before you call the agent.

STAGE 1 • THIS DOCUMENT

Pre-Offer Assessment

Desktop checks in 30–60 minutes. Kill bad sites fast before you spend any money or emotional energy.

STAGE 2 • AFTER OFFER ACCEPTED

2-Day Cooling-Off Sprint

Secure the site first. Then call your surveyor, arborist, designer, builder, and planning consultant. Cross-reference everything.

Ten checks before you make an offer. All of them are potential deal killers — not margin adjustments. If you hit one, stop and investigate before going further.

01 Does the zoning permit what you want to build?

Open the SA Planning Portal and check the zone and every overlay. A Character Overlay is a near-automatic no-go — even when development is permitted, the design requirements it imposes will almost always make the project unviable.

02 Are there protected trees on or near the frontage?

SA tree legislation has tightened significantly. Council verge trees are protected — you cannot remove them and cannot position a crossover too close to them. If a tree sits where your crossover needs to go, parking compliance becomes impossible. If you're unsure, engage a highly regarded arborist before you commit.

03 Can you get a crossover in at the right position?

Scan every metre of the frontage on Google Street View. SA Water pits, electricity plinths, power poles, bus stops, road islands, and median strips can all block a crossover. You need a legal crossover position for each dwelling's parking — if you can't get one, the project doesn't proceed regardless of everything else.

04 What type of road is it?

A quiet residential street is ideal. A narrow street is worth a closer look — access and parking can become complicated. A semi-main road introduces noise, traffic, and buyer hesitation that will discount your end value. A main road — avoid it entirely. The lifestyle discount is structural and won't go away.

05 Are there easements that will kill the design?

Ask the agent for the title — they'll provide it for free. It shows SA Water, electricity, gas, and stormwater easements. An easement through the building envelope ends the project — and the vendor has no obligation to disclose it. Do this before you offer, not after.

06 Does the lot meet the minimum allotment size?

Check the Planning and Design Code for the minimum for your development type and zone. Council may allow up to approximately 5% below the minimum, but only if everything else in your application is perfect and nothing else is being varied.

07 Does the frontage meet the minimum?

General Neighbourhood minimums: 9m for a 2-site development, 7m for a 3-site row. Confirm on the title — SA titles are often in imperial, so convert to metric. Council may allow the same approximate 5% tolerance on frontage, but again only if everything else in the application is perfect.

08 Has someone already tried to develop this and failed?

Ask the agent why the vendor is selling. Estate sales and financial pressure are fine. A vendor who applied for development approval and was refused is a red flag — find out why. It may be fixable, or it may be permanent.

09 How does the site slope?

Every metre of fall adds \$8,000–\$15,000 in earthworks. Drive past — you'll see it immediately. A site draining away from the street with no outlet may need a pump system. Your surveyor will quantify it precisely once you're under contract.

10 What's on the site, and is demolition clean?

Pre-1990 buildings in Adelaide almost certainly contain asbestos — add \$8,000–\$25,000 to demolition. Check Street View for granny flats, separate meters, or structures that may need council approval to remove.

"The hardest part isn't finding a site or even running the numbers. It's closing — knowing how to secure a site when you're confident it works. Most people hesitate at exactly that moment."

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The Cooling-Off Sprint — Who to Call and Why

Secure the site first. Once you're under contract the clock starts and everyone has a reason to engage. The goal is to cross-reference everything and leave no stone unturned. The more people you speak to, the clearer the picture.

Surveyor — First call

Don't approach a surveyor with a hypothetical before you've secured the site — you'll wear out goodwill you'll need later. Once you're under contract, call them immediately and ask for their initial read on viability. You're not asking for a full report — just their experienced opinion on the site. That's a different conversation and they're usually happy to have it.

Arborist — If trees are in play

If there are trees near the crossover position or on the verge, engage a highly regarded arborist immediately. SA tree legislation has tightened. You need a qualified, respected opinion on what's protected, what can be removed, and what constraints apply. Don't guess on this one.

Designer — Early in the sprint

Brief your designer as soon as you have the surveyor's initial read. You need a concept layout that confirms the design is viable, parking works, and private open space is achievable. This is the document that tells you whether everything fits within the real constraints of the site.

Builder — Site visit if possible

A good builder will often be willing to walk the site with you during cooling-off. That's enormously valuable — they see cost implications you won't. At minimum you need a rough construction cost range to confirm the feasibility still works. Not a quote — a range.

Planning Consultant — Worth their weight in gold

Find someone who is ex-council and knows how to navigate the specific council your site sits in. These people understand how an assessment team actually thinks — not just what the code says. They will also often know about any local issues, overlays, or nuances that aren't obvious from a desktop review. They are worth every dollar.

Building Permit Consultant

People who specialise in building permit applications at council level — often also ex-council — can flag compliance issues early and advise on how to frame your application for the best outcome. Getting this right from the start saves months of back-and-forth later in the process.

"This checklist covers the site assessment. It deliberately leaves out feasibility — build costs, acquisition price, operational costs, resale values, how to get accurate numbers from agents and builders. That's a separate discipline and it's covered elsewhere. What I've found after 25+ years in sales is that the hardest part isn't finding a site or even running the numbers. It's closing — knowing how to secure a site when you're confident it works. Most people hesitate at exactly that moment. That's where I can help most. If you've got a site you're looking at and you're not sure how to move on it, call me."

GUY MOORE

Founder, Moore Consultants • \$23M+ Completed Adelaide Coastal Projects

Got a site you're looking at?

Bring it to a free 30-minute consultation. Guy will tell you whether it's worth pursuing — or save you from one that isn't.

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